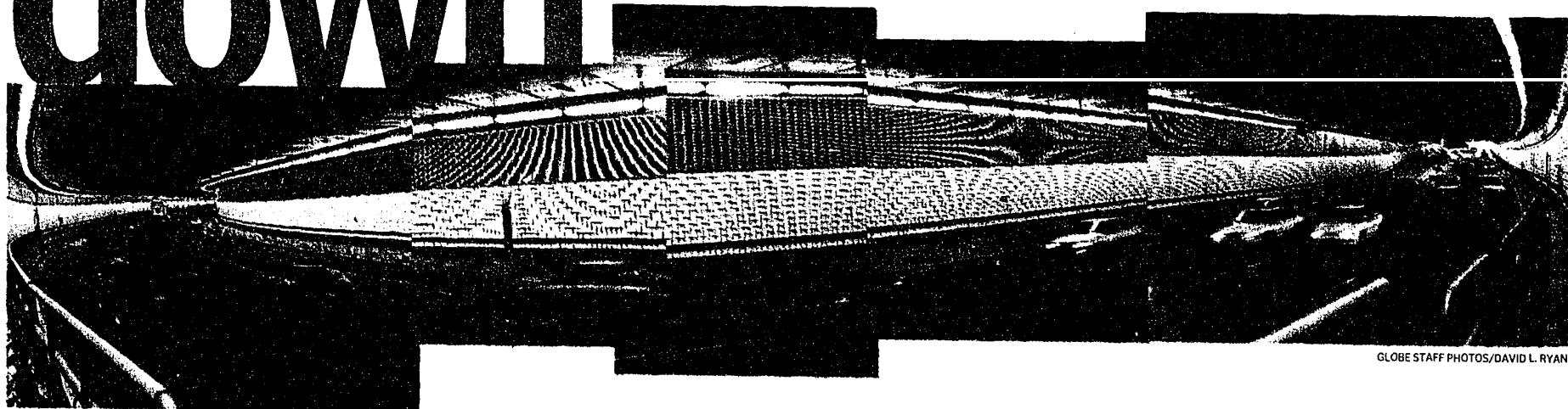


When driving through the new Central Artery tunnels, it's best to keep your eyes on the road: It seems that saving money on finishing touches meant creating ugliness around every turn.

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GLOBE STAFF PHOTOS/DAVID L. RYAN

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Doesn't anyone care what anything looks like anymore?

Grab your car and take a drive through the new tunnels of the Big Dig. Cast your gaze upward, into the ghastly black hole that is, in most of the tunnels, what passes for a ceiling. Sometimes the upper walls are black, too. We've spent \$15 billion to build tunnels that feel like coal mines.

Connoisseurs of architectural disaster should make a special point of driving the ramps that lead onto and off of Storrow Drive. This is where the tunnel top is at its worst. You seem to be looking up at a shapeless tangle of

beams, girders, and ducts that have been sprayed with a thick coat of soot. You expect bats to fly out. At least no one will have to worry about dirt collecting here. We've found the solution to that: instant, artificial filth.

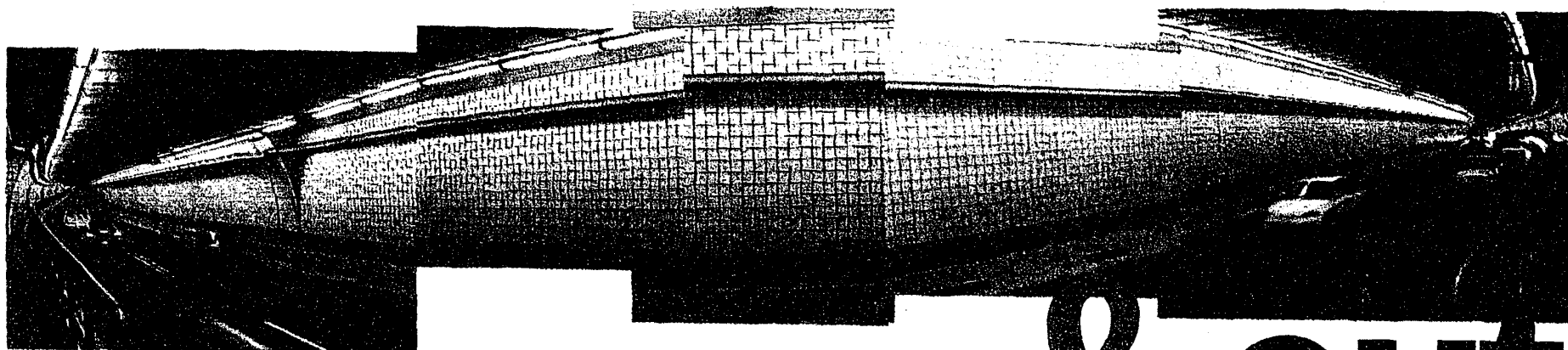
Why the black hole? The answer, as you'd suspect, is money. The tunnel's designers decided that the cost-effective solution to finishing the ceiling, in most places, was simply to paint everything black.

To see how different things could have been, drive the Ted Williams Tunnel between the South Boston exit and Logan. Here the ceilings are porcelain enamel panels, with a light-toned, semigloss finish. The tile on the walls reaches all the way up to meet the ceiling. Nothing is black. I wouldn't call the result great, but it's acceptable, a lot better than the Halloween caverns elsewhere.

Why does the Ted Williams Tunnel look so much better? Mainly because it was built earlier in the process, when the Massachusetts Turnpike Authority's budget wasn't yet being tested. That's why the wall tile goes all the way up, and that's why the ceiling has the handsome porcelain finish. In the other tunnels, most of the ceilings are made of plain concrete panels painted black.

Worst of all, there are some places, as in the Storrow ramps, where there's no ceiling at all. There's just black structural and mechanical bric-a-brac. The explanation for that is interesting, if depressing: You have to exhaust the air from a tunnel. In the earlier tunnels, that was accomplished through a huge duct along the top of the tunnel. The duct had to be protected, so there had to be a

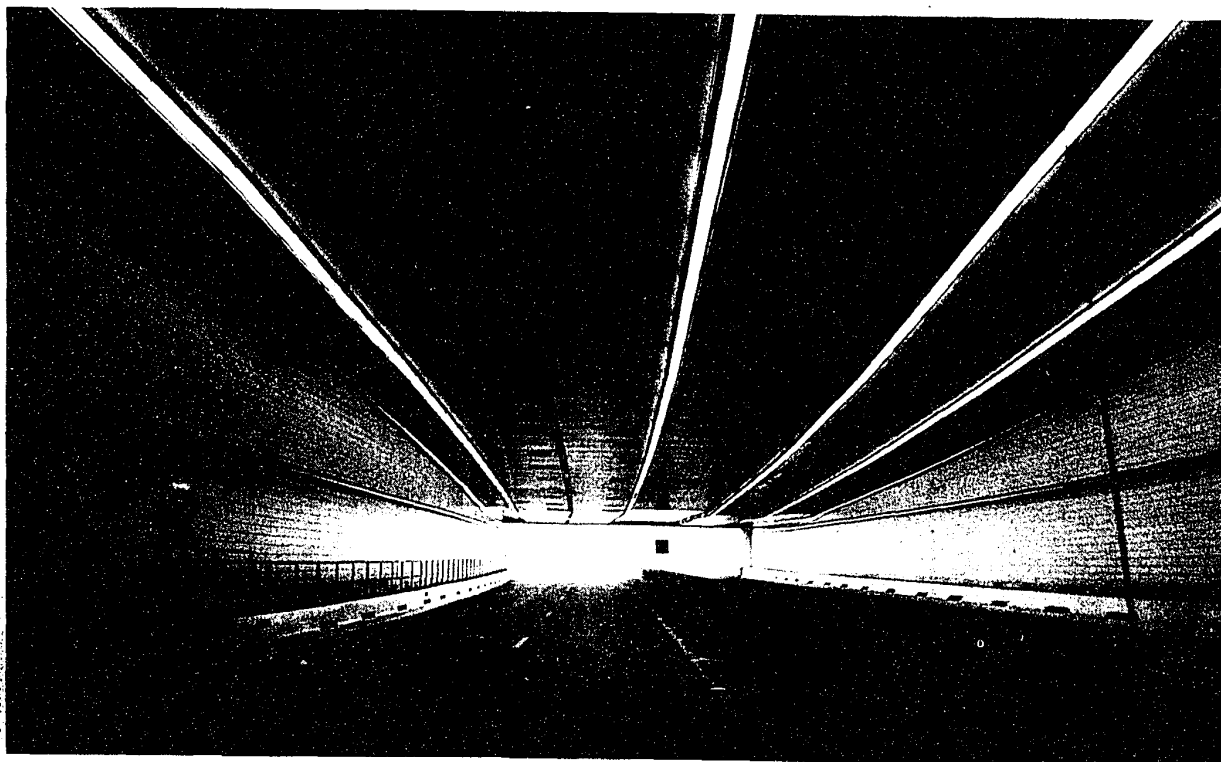
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The ceiling in a Central Artery tunnel (top) is less attractive than that in the older Ted Williams Tunnel.

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*What happened to the tunnels is what tends to happen on any construction project.
When the budget crunch hits, it's the finishes that suffer.*



GLOBE STAFF PHOTO/DAVID L. RYAN

In the Ted Williams Tunnel, the wall tiles reach all the way up to the ceiling, which is made of porcelain enamel panels.

Central Artery tunnels are not big on beauty

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ceiling. In some of the later tunnels, however, the exhaust is handled more cheaply by big cylindrical fans (black, of course) that hang on the walls and just blow the bad air out the end of the tunnel. So there's no practical need for a ceiling. It's simply omitted. More money saved, more ugliness created.

Still another source of visual blight are the radio cables, which are strung along the tunnel walls on both sides. They're black, too. In the Ted Williams Tunnel, they're enclosed in metal raceways, but elsewhere they're lazily strung up like laundry lines. They look like afterthoughts.

Even the roadbeds, brand new, can be a problem. I was trying to do a crossword puzzle in a taxi to Logan several weeks ago, a situation in which you're sensitive to any roughness in the ride. Parts of the surface approaching the airport are surprisingly bumpy. It's obviously been improperly installed.

OK, one more thing. You need to know why on earth there are those tacky steel grilles at the top of so many tunnel walls.

Here's the explanation. Some — not all — of the tunnel walls are so-called slurry walls, concrete walls that hold back the earth behind them. Slurry walls are ugly. Moisture penetrates them and causes a whitish efflorescence. They start to look diseased.

To save money, the white tile that covers the walls stops well short of the ceiling (except at the Williams tunnel, where, as noted, it goes all the way up). Thus there's a gap at the upper wall, exposing the concrete behind. The original solution, no surprise, was to paint the concrete black.

But in the case of the slurry walls, the painted concrete looked especially hideous. Matthew Amorello, the Turnpike Authority chairman, decided the slurry-wall gaps should be covered. Tile was regarded as too costly, so the job was done with the stainless-steel grilles. You assume they must have some function, but they

don't. They're just cosmetic. I suppose they're better than looking at pustulating slurry walls. But they look cheap and slapped-on.

We've seen this before. The Mass. Pike tunnel under the Prudential has a black, no-ceiling top, and it's hideous. But the Callahan and Sumner tunnels, also owned by the Turnpike Authority, were refurbished a few years ago and look a lot better than the new Central Artery tunnels. Of course, the real comparison is with public works in places such as Western Europe or East Asia, where there's often a genuine elegance in the design of the public realm.

David Dixon, a Boston architect and planner, has a suggestion for the Central Artery tunnels. Why not hold an artists' competition to invent better ceilings? Maybe something in neon? Maybe projected images? Such a ceiling could be temporary and could even change every few months.

What happened to the tunnels is what tends to happen on any construction project. When the budget crunch hits, it's the finishes that suffer. The Turnpike Authority has one other big finish job in the works. It's the landscaping and other improvements to the Rose Kennedy Greenway on the land above the tunnels. The Turnpike's record of cutting finishes in the tunnels, without regard to looks or the pleasure of the user, doesn't bode well for the quality of work we can expect on the surface. As the Artery project nears its end, everyone should be alert. The best hope here is probably the new, impressively qualified design advisory panel that the Pike recently appointed to oversee the Greenway's design.

Many cities and towns now enforce a 1-percent-for-art law, in which a portion of the cost of any public project must be devoted to art. Maybe we need another law: 1 percent for finishing the job. In the case of the Artery project, that would come to \$150 million. It should be enough to buy some tile and porcelain.

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